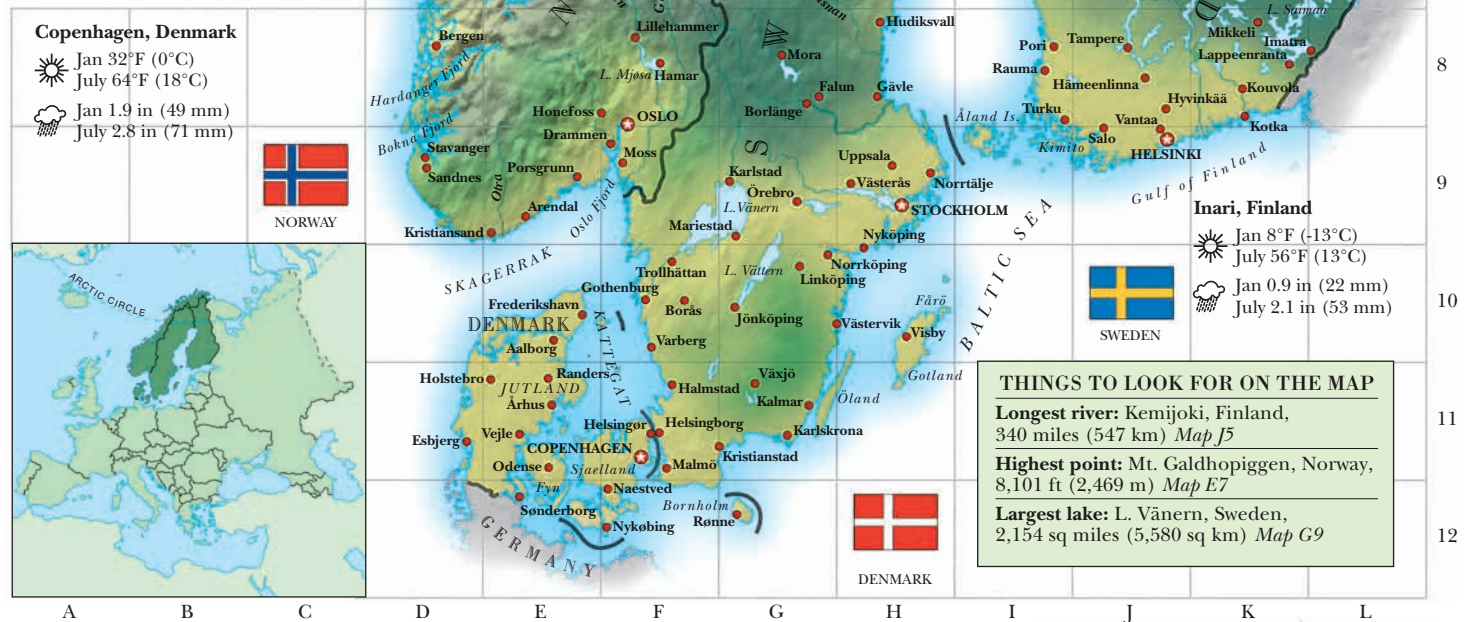


SCANDINAVIA AND FINLAND

THE NORTHERN EUROPEAN countries of Norway, Sweden, and Denmark are together known as Scandinavia. Along with neighboring Finland, all four countries have small populations and enjoy a high standard of living with extensive social welfare systems that distribute wealth evenly among the people. Much of Norway, Sweden, and Finland is covered by forests of pine, spruce, and birch trees, riddled with lakes gouged out by glaciers during the last Ice Age. Norway and Sweden are mountainous, while Finland and fertile Denmark are low-lying.



THE MIDNIGHT SUN
Much of northern Norway, Sweden, and Finland lie in the Arctic Circle. Here the Sun never sets at the height of summer – giving 24 hours of light – and never rises in the middle of winter – giving 24 hours of darkness. The periods of light or dark lengthen the farther north you go. In the far north the winter darkness lasts for almost two months.

Midnight Sun in Senja, Norway



COASTLINE CITIES

Most people in the region live in towns and cities around the coast or on lakesides. These stretches of water provide the best form of transportation in an area where fast-flowing rivers are unsuitable and where much of the interior is rugged. The capitals of all four countries are on the coast, including Stockholm, the Swedish capital, which lies on the edge of the Baltic Sea.

